a year later, Vipul was sent for an operation in Iraq. He was fluent in Arabic, Dari, Urdu, German and Russian. Languages and an ascetic smile were his weapons of choice. He loved Sanskrit and spent his free time reading about Sufi mystics. This colourful personality was just one side of the man. The other side was completely mysterious. As a professional spy, Vipul Chandra was cunning, possessed the ability to sniff out intelligence from miles away, a warrior loyal to his country and skilled enough in defence techniques to kill a man with his bare hands. His physique, friends teased, was made of steel.

While he was in Iraq sometime in mid-1984, Vipul received a call from Delhi, summoning him to an urgent meeting back home. India was facing both an internal and an external turmoil at the time and Vipul was needed in another theatre.

Since 1979, when the Khomeini-led movement had forced the Shah of Iran to step down and seek shelter elsewhere to survive, India's equation with Iran had turned hostile. Once a close friend, Iran viewed India as a power that had supported the Shah's rule and was now siding with the USA and other western powers.

Khomeini's apprehensions were true to a certain extent, Vipul's boss explained, but India had always followed the policy of non-alignment and talk about the India-US-Shah ties were part of a propaganda war launched by inimical forces to widen the rift between India and Iran.

Vipul was familiar with Khomeini's hard views on the USA. The cleric had once famously said: Any weapon whether it is a pen, a gun should not be employed against one another. Instead, they should be aimed directly at the enemies of humanity, on top of them the governments of United States.' Besides, the escalating